Extracto: Kagan on Consequentialism

Passage taken from:
Kagan, Shelly (1998). "Normative Ethics". Boulder, CO: Westview, pp. 154-155.

(For the record: Shelly Kagan here lays out an argument that other philosophers have given, and which Kagan himself does not accept. Students interested in seeing the classic statement of this kind of argument are encouraged to check out Bernard Williams's (1973) chapter in the Consequentialism folder in the LMS. (Williams's own version, important as it is, requires too much setup; it does not work well as a short passage for this exercise.)

Shelly Kagan:

Let's consider a case [...]. .... suppose (as is indeed the case)
p.154 that by sending ten dollars to a suitable charity you could save the life of a child who would otherwise die. Imagine, then, that you are about to spend this much to see a movie. But as you approach the ticket office, someone collecting for the charity asks you to skip the movie and make a contribution of the money instead. Clearly you are *permitted* to do this; normally, after all, one has no special obligation to see a movie. But are you morally *required* to make the contribution?

From the consequentialist perspective, answering the question requires comparing two possible outcomes. On the one hand, you could go to the movie and enjoy yourself for a few hours; on the other hand, you could forgo the movie, and save a child's life. Now on any plausible theory of the good, the pleasure you get from seeing the movie will count for *something*—but saving the life of the child will count for much, much more. So in terms of outcomes, the results will be much better *overall* (that is, counting everyone equally) if you give the money to the charity rather than spending it on the movie. But consequentialism says that you are required to perform the act that will have the best results overall. And so (assuming that there is no third act available to you right now that would have even better results) you are indeed required to make the contribution. Going to the movie is morally *forbidden*.

p.155 I suspect, however, that the most common response to this case would be rather different. I take it that a more typical view would maintain that although it would be morally *meritorious* for you to make this sacrifice, you are certainly not morally *required* to make it. Sacrificing your personal pleasure in this way is above and beyond the call of duty; it is *supererogatory* (a term traditionally used to mark acts that, although meritorious, are not obligatory). Matters would no doubt be quite different if it were somehow your fault that the child was in need; then you might well have a special obligation to provide aid. But in the situation we are imagining, where you are not at all responsible for the plight of the child, making the sacrifice is doing more than morality requires of you.

Background / Set up

State the argument in outline

Explain Any Rationales for the Premises

Evaluate the argument

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